

Said al-Andalusi, Tabaqat al-Umam

Reference Text

Modern LaTeX Editions of Public-Domain Mathematics Manuscripts

كِتَابُ الْأُمَمِ طَبَقَاتِ

الْأَنْدَلُسِيُّ صَاعِدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدِ الْقَاسِمِ أَبِي الْقَاضِي

(م ١٠٧٠-١٠٦٩ هـ ٤٦٢ سَنَةِ الْمَتَوَفَى)

وَالْفَهَارِسِ بِالرُّوَايَاتِ وَارِدَةً بِالْحَوَاشِي وَذَيْلُهُ نُشْرُهُ

الْيَسُوعِيُّ شَيْخُو لُؤَيْسَ الْأَبِّ

الشَّرْقِ جَمْلَةً مِنْ عَشْرَةِ الرَّابِعَةِ السَّنَةِ فِي بَتْنَايِعِ نُشْرَ

الْيَسُوعِيِّينَ لِلْأَبَاءِ الْكَاثُولِيكِيَّةِ الْمَطْبَعَةُ

١٩١٢ بَيْرُوتَ

KITAB TABAQAT AL-UMAM

(BOOK OF THE CATEGORIES OF NATIONS)

By

**Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id
al-Andalusi**

(d. 462 AH / 1070 CE)

Edited with Notes, Variants, and Indexes by

Pere Louis Cheikho, S.J.

Al-Matba'a al-Kathulikiyya li-l-Aba' al-Yasusiyyin

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Editor's Introduction

الأمم طبقات كتاب

الأندلسي صاعد بن أحمد بن صاعد القاسم أبي القاضي

توطئة

سَبَقَتْ الَّتِي الْأُمَمُ بَيْنَ الْعُلُومِ لَوْضِفِ الْعَرَبِ كَتَبَتْ فِيهَا نَعَرَضُ الَّتِي النَّادِرَةُ الْكُتُبِ أَحَدُ الْأُمَمِ طَبَقَاتِ كِتَابٍ تَذُلُ فَوَائِدَ عِدَّةٍ جَمَعَ أَنَّهُ إِلَّا الدَّمِيمِ ابْنِ الْفَرَجِ لِأَبِي الْفَهْرِسْتِ كِتَابٍ شَأُو ذَلِكَ فِي صَاحِبِهِ يَبْلُغُ لَمْ وَإِنْ عَهْدَهُمْ، بِهِ يَفْتَحِرُونَ الْأَنْدَلُسِ أَهْلُ وَكَانَ التَّنْوِينِ، فِي نَظَرٍ وَدَقَّةٍ التَّحْصِيلِ فِي رَغْبَةٍ وَعَلَى الْبَحْثِ فِي نَشَاطٍ عَلَى عَبْدِ عَنْ بَجْرِيظٍ [طَبْعَةُ ٤٦٣: ٢] الصَّلَةِ لِكِتَابِ التَّكْمِلَةِ كِتَابٍ فِي الْأَبَارِ ابْنُ ذَكَرٍ وَقَدْ الشَّرْقِ. لَاهِلٍ وَبِرُؤُوسِ السَّلَفِيِّ. طَاهِرٍ لِأَبِي الْكِتَابِ هَذَا رَوَى الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةُ قَدَّمَ لِمَا لِلَّهِ الْيَحْصِي مَرْزُوقٍ بِنِ مُحَمَّدٍ بِنِ اللَّهِ تَارِيخِ كِتَابٍ فِي عَنْهُ نَقَلَ فَإِنَّهُ الْعَبْرِيُّ ابْنُ غُرَيْغُورِيُوسِ الْفَرَجِ أَبُو الشَّرْقِ فِي الْكِتَابِ هَذَا عَرَفُوا وَمِمَّنْ عَرَفَهُ وَكَذَلِكَ وَعُلُومِهِمْ، الْعَرَبِ فِي مُفِيدَتَيْنِ نَبَذَتَيْنِ الْبَيْرُوتِيَّةِ [طَبْعَتَا مِنْ ١٣٥ و ١٥٨] ص الدُّوَلِ مُخْتَصَرٍ بِطَبَقَاتِ التَّعْرِيفِ لِبَسِيكَ [طَبْعَةُ ٨١٢: ٣] فِي تَارَةً فَدَعَا الطُّنُونِ كَشَفَ كِتَابِهِ فِي مَرَارًا فَذَكَرَهُ خَلِيفَةُ الْحَاجِّ هَذِهِ وَكَفَى الْأُمَمِ. طَبَقَاتِ كِتَابٍ [١٣٣]: ٤ وَتَارَةً التَّفْعِ، كَثِيرُ الْحَجْمِ صَغِيرُ كِتَابٍ إِنَّهُ وَصَفِهِ فِي وَقَالَ الْأُمَمِ وَمَوْتُوْقِهِ. لِلْكِتَابِ الْقَدَمَاءِ اغْتِبَارٍ عَلَى دَلِيلًا الْمَنْقُولَاتِ

[Translation of the Editor's Introduction]

Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam (The Book of the Categories of Nations) is one of the rare works in which an Arab writer describes the sciences among the nations that preceded his era. Although its author did not reach the level of Abu al-Faraj ibn al-Damimi in his *Fihrist*, he nevertheless collected numerous useful facts that demonstrate his research activity, his desire for knowledge, and his precision in observation. The people of al-Andalus used to boast of him and of the heads of the East.

Ibn al-Abb'ar mentions in his *Takmila* to the *Silah* (2:463, Bajarid edition) on the authority of Abd Allah ibn Muhammad ibn Marzuq al-Yahsibi—may God reward him for what he presented to Alexandria—that he transmitted this book to Abu Tahir al-Salafi.

Among those who knew this book in the East was Abu al-Faraj Grigoriyus ibn al-'Ibri, for he quoted from it in his *History of the Dynasties* (p. 158 and 135 in our Beirut edition) two useful excerpts concerning the Arabs and their sciences. Likewise, al-Hajj Khalifa knew it and mentioned it several times in his *Kashf al-Zunun*: at one point (3:812, Lipsik edition) calling it *Ta'rif bi-Tabaqat al-Umam*, and describing it as a small book of great benefit; at another point (4:133) as *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam*. These quotations suffice as proof of the esteem and trust the ancients had for this book.

مُثَقِّنًا تَجْلِيدًا وَمُجَلَّدَةً الصَّفَرَةَ إِلَى صَارِبٍ صَفِيْقٍ وَرَقٍ عَلَى الْفَارَسِيِّ بِالْقَلَمِ شَبِيهِ جَلِيٍّ بِخَطِّ مَكْتُوبَةٍ وَهِيَ مِنْ فِيهَا وَقَعَ مَا مَعَ حَسَنَةً بِالْإِجْمَالِ وَالنُّسْخَةَ زَيْنَةً، مِثْلَهُمَا لِسَانٍ مَعَ الْوَجْهَيْنِ عَلَى ذَهَبِيٍّ مُلَوَّنٍ وَرَقٍ بِجَلْدٍ طَبَعْتَنَا. ذَلِيلٍ فِي عَلَيْهَا فَتَبَّهْنَا أَكْثَرَهَا إِصْلَاحَ أَمَكْنَا الَّتِي الْأَغْلَاطِ

بَجْرِيظٍ [طَبْعَةُ الصَّلَةِ كِتَابٍ فِي بِشْكَوَالِ ابْنِ رَوَاهَا كَمَا تَرْجَمْتُهُ وَهَذِهِ أَمْرِهِ، مِنْ الْأَقْلِ نَعْلَمُ فَلَا الْمُؤَلَّفُ أَمَا عَنْهُ: قَالَ ٢٣٤ ص

قُرْطَبَةَ مِنْ وَأَصْلُهُ الْقَاسِمِ أَبِي بَكْنِيَّةِ الْقَاضِي التَّغْلِبِيُّ صَاعِدِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ الرَّحْمَنِ عَبْدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ [صَاعِدِ] صَاعِدِ ذِي بَنِي يَحْيَى الْأَمِيرِ وَاسْتَقْضَاهُ وَغَيْرِهِمْ، الْوُفْشِيُّ الْوَلِيدِ وَأَبِي قَاسِمِ بْنِ وَالْفَتْحِ حَزْمِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدِ أَبِي عَنْ رُوي عَلَى وَبِالشَّهَادَةِ الْحُقُوقِ فِي الْوَاحِدِ الشَّاهِدِ مَعَ بِالْيَمِينِ الْقَضَاةَ وَإِخْتِبَارِ أُمُورِهِ فِي مُتَحَرَّرًا وَكَانَ بِطَلِبَةِ الثُّونِ ١٠٣٩ هـ ٤٢٠ سَنَةٍ فِي بِالْمَرِيَّةِ وَلِدَ وَالرَّوَايَةَ، وَالذِّكَاةِ الْمَعْرِفَةِ أَهْلٍ مِنْ وَكَانَ نَظَرِهِ، أَيَّامَ بِذَلِكَ وَقَضَى الْحُطِّ

عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ م ١٠٧٠ هـ ٤٦٢ مائة وأربع وستين اثنتين سنة شوال في قاضيها وهو بطليلة وتوفي م
مطاهر ابن بَعْضُهُ ذَكَرَ الْحَدِيدِي. بْنُ سَعِيدِ بْنِ يَحْيَى

[Manuscript Description]

[The manuscript is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script, on thick paper tending toward yellow, and bound with skillful binding in colored gold paper on both sides with a matching tongue as ornament. The manuscript is, in general, fine despite the errors that occurred in it, most of which we were able to correct and have indicated in the notes to our edition.]

[Biography of the Author]

As for the author, we know no less than what Ibn Bashkuwal narrated in his *Silah* (Bajarid edition, p. 234):

“Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Abd al-Rahman ibn Muhammad ibn Sa'id al-Taghlabi, the judge with the kunya Abu al-Qasim, originally from Cordoba, transmitted from Abu Muhammad ibn Hazm, al-Fath ibn Qasim, Abu al-Walid al-Waqshi, and others. The amir Yahya ibn Dhi al-Nun appointed him as judge of Tulaytula (Toledo), and he was independent in his affairs and in testing judges by oath along with one witness in lawsuits and by testimony regarding handwriting, and judgments were made accordingly during his tenure. He was a man of knowledge, intelligence, and transmission. He was born in al-Mariyya (Almeria) in 420 AH (1039 CE) and died in Tulaytula while serving as its judge in Shawwal of the year 462 AH (1070 CE). Yahya ibn Sa'id ibn al-Hadidi prayed over him. Ibn Mutahir mentioned part of this.”

The Book of the Categories of Nations

الْأُمَمِ طَبَقَاتِ كِتَابُ

الْأَنْدَلُسِيُّ صَاعِدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدِ الْقَاسِمِ أَبِي الْقَاضِي

Chapter One: The Ancient Nations

الرَّحِيمِ الرَّحْمَنِ اللَّهُ بِسْمِ
يَسِّرْ رَبِّ

الْأَرْضِ مَشَارِقَ فِي النَّاسِ جَمِيعَ أَنْ أَعْلَمَ تَعَالَى: اللَّهُ رَحِمَهُ صَاعِدِ بْنِ أَحْمَدَ بْنِ صَاعِدِ الْقَاسِمِ أَبُو الْقَاضِي قَالَ
¹وَاللُّغَاتِ. وَالصُّورِ بِالْأَخْلَاقِ أَشْيَاءَ: بِثَلَاثَةٍ يَتَمَيَّزُونَ وَاحِدًا نَوْعًا كَانُوا وَإِنْ وَشَمَالِهَا وَجَنُوبِهَا وَمَغَارِبِهَا

²الْقَدِيمَةِ □ الْأُمَمِ : الْأَوَّلُ □ الْبَابُ

سَالِفٍ فِي كَانُوا النَّاسِ أَنَّ الْقُرُونِ طَبَقَاتٍ عَنْ وَفَحَصَ الْأَجْيَالِ سَائِرَ عَنْ وَبَحَثَ الْأُمَمِ بِأَخْبَارِ عُنِّي مَنْ وَرَعَمَ
الْمَعْمُورِ الْوَسْطِ فِي مَسْكَنُهَا وَكَانَ الْفُرْسِ الْأُولَى □ □ الْأُمَّةُ أُمَمٌ سَبْعَ اللُّغَاتِ وَافْتِرَاقِ الْقَبَائِلِ تَشَعُّبٍ وَقَبْلَ الدُّهُورِ
وَهَمْدَانَ وَالْدُّسْتُورُ وَالْكُرْجُ الْأَنْجَهَاتُ فِيهِ وَالَّذِي حُلْوَانَ بِعَقَبَةِ الْعِرَاقِ شِمَالٍ فِي الَّتِي الْجِبَالِ مِنْ بِلَادِهَا وَحَدِّ
وَالْبَيْلِقَانَ وَمَوْلَتَانَ وَطَبْرِسْتَانَ أَذْرَبِجَانَ بِبَحْرِ الْمُتَّصِلِ وَالْبَابِ أَرْمِينِيَّةَ إِلَى الْبِلَادِ مِنْ وَغَيْرِهَا وَقَاشَانَ وَقُمَّ
وَحُورِزْمَ وَهَرَاةَ وَسَرَخْسَ وَالْمَرْوِ كَنْيْشَابُورَ خُرَاسَانَ بِلَادٍ إِلَى وَجُرْجَانَ وَالطَّلِقَانَ وَالرِّيَّ وَالشَّابَرَانَ وَأَرَزْنَ
وَبُجَارًا. وَيُلْخَ

[Translation:]

In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate.

O Lord, make it easy!

The judge Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id—may God the Exalted have mercy on him—said: Know that all people in the East and West of the Earth, in its South and North, though they are one species, are distinguished by three things: by their moral character, their physical forms, and their languages.

Those who have concerned themselves with the reports of nations and investigated the various generations, and examined the categories of ages, say that in earliest times, before the branching of tribes and the divergence of languages, there were seven nations:

The First Nation: The Persians. Their dwelling was in the middle of the inhabited world. Their lands include the mountains in the north of Iraq, the region of Hulwan, and the area containing the Anjahat, Kuraj, Dustur, Hamadan, Qumm, Qashan, and other lands extending to Armenia, the Gate connecting to the Sea of Azerbaijan, Tabaristan, Multan, Bilaqan, Arzan, Shaboran, al-Rayy, Taliqan, and Jurjan, to the lands of Khurasan—Nayshabur, Marw, Sarakhs, Harat, Khwarizm, Balkh, and Bujara.

¹The author here sets forth the fundamental unity of humankind while acknowledging three sources of differentiation: moral character (*akhlāq*), physical appearance (*ṣuwar*), and language (*lughāt*). This tripartite division reflects the anthropological understanding of the 11th century.

²Chapter One: The Ancient Nations. These are the peoples who lived in the earliest ages of the world, before the rise of the great civilizations of the Near East.

Chapter Two: Science in India

الهند في العلم

وَرَدَتْ وَلَا عُلُومِهِمْ مِنْ طَرَفٍ إِلَيْنَا نَصِلَ فَلَمْ نَأْلِفْهُمْ فَلَمْ وَبَيْنَهُمْ بَيْنَنَا الْمَالِكِ وَاعْتَرَا ضِ بِلَادِنَا مِنَ الْهِنْدِ وَلِبَعْدِ عِلْمِهِمْ. مِنْ بِالْقَلِيلِ إِلَّا سَمِعْنَا وَلَا مَذَاهِبِهِمْ مِنْ تُبْدُ إِلَّا عَلَيْنَا الْأَزْدِيحِ وَمَذَهَبُ هِنْدِ السُّنْدِ مَذَهَبٌ وَهُوَ عَنْهُمْ الْمَشْهُورَةُ الثَّلَاثَةُ الْمَذَهَبُ النُّجُومِ عُلُومِ فِي الْهِنْدِ مَذَاهِبُ فَمِنْ جَمَاعَةٍ تَقْلَدُهُ الَّذِي الْمَذَهَبُ وَهُوَ هِنْدِ السُّنْدِ مَذَهَبٌ إِلَّا التَّحْصِيلِ عَلَى مِنْهُمْ إِلَيْنَا يَصِلُ وَلَمْ الْأَرْكَانِ وَمَذَهَبُ مُوسَى بْنِ وَمُحَمَّدِ الْبَغْدَادِيِّ اللَّهِ عَبْدُ بْنُ وَحَبِشِ الْفَارَازِيِّ إِبْرَاهِيمَ بْنِ كَمُحَمَّدِ الْأَزْيَاجِ فِيهِ وَالْقَوَامِ الْإِسْلَامِ مِنْ كَذَلِكَ الدَّاهِرُ [] [] [] الدَّهْرُ هِنْدِ السُّنْدِ وَتَفْسِيرُ وَغَيْرِهِمْ. الْأَدَمِيِّ بِابْنِ الْمَعْرُوفِ مُحَمَّدِ بْنِ وَالْحُسَيْنِ الْخَوَارِزْمِيِّ زِيَجِهِ. فِي الْأَدَمِيِّ بْنِ الْحُسَيْنِ حَكِي

فَصْلٌ

أَنْ ذَكَرُواهَا الَّتِي مَذَهَبُهُمْ فَإِنَّ الْعَالَمَ مَدَّةٌ عَدَدٌ أَلَا هِنْدِ السُّنْدِ أَصْحَابٌ وَافَقُوا فَإِنَّهُمْ هِنْدِ السُّنْدِ أَصْحَابٌ وَأَمَّا وَالْأَوْجَاتِ الْكَوَاكِبِ حَرَكَاتٍ أَبَدًا تِلْكَ الْأَمْرُ ذَلِكَ فَمَنْذُ الْحَمَلِ رَأْسٍ فِي مُجْتَمَعَتِ وَجُوزْهَرَاتِهَا وَأَوْجَاتِهَا الْكَوَاكِبِ وَالْجُوزْهَرَاتِ وَالْأَوْجَاتِ الْكَوَاكِبِ تَتَفَرَّقُ حَتَّى طَوِيلًا دَهْرًا خَرَابًا السُّفْلَى الْعَالَمِ وَبَقِيَ الْأَرْضِ فِي وَالْجُوزْهَرَاتِ وَلِكُلِّ عِنْدَهُمْ. غَايَةٌ غَيْرٌ إِلَى أَبَدًا هَكَذَا الْأَوَّلِ الْأَمْرِ إِلَى السُّفْلَى الْعَالَمِ حَالَةٌ بَدَأَتْ كَذَلِكَ كَانَ فَإِذَا الْبُرُوجِ فِي ذَكَرْتُهَا. قَدْ الْعَالَمِ مَدَّةٌ عِنْدَهُمْ هِيَ الَّتِي الْمُدَّةُ هَذِهِ فِي مَا أَدْوَارَ وَالْجُوزْهَرَاتِ وَالْأَوْجَاتِ الْكَوَاكِبِ مِنْ وَاحِدٍ

[Translation: Science in India]

Because of the distance of India from our lands and the obstacles between us and them, we have not become familiar with them. No portion of their sciences has reached us, nothing has come to us but fragments of their doctrines, and we have heard only a little of their knowledge.

Among the doctrines of the Indians in the science of astrology, three doctrines are famous among them: the doctrine of Sindhind, the doctrine of the Azij, and the doctrine of Arkand. Only the doctrine of Sindhind has reached us in a complete form. It was followed by a group of Muslims, and those who established it were al-Azyaj such as Muhammad ibn Ibrahim al-Fazari, Habash ibn Abd Allah al-Baghdadi, Muhammad ibn Musa al-Khwarizmi, al-Husayn ibn Muhammad known as Ibn al-Adami, and others. The interpretation of Sindhind is "the Eternal Time" (al-Dahr al-Dahir), as al-Husayn ibn al-Adami related in his zij.

[Section]

As for the followers of Sindhind, they agree that the duration of the world has no fixed number. Their doctrine which they mention is that the planets, their apogees, and their nodes were all gathered at the head of Aries. Since that event, the movements of the planets, apogees, and nodes began. The lower world remained desolate for a long time until the planets, apogees, and nodes dispersed through the zodiac signs. When that happened, the condition of the lower world returned to its first state, and this continues without end according to them. Each of the planets, apogees, and nodes has cycles during this period, which they consider the duration of the world, which I have mentioned.

Chapter Three: Science among the Persians

الْفُرسِ فِي الْعِلْمِ

أَقْلِيَمًا وَأَشْرَفَهَا دَارًا الْأُمَمِ وَأَوْسَطِ الشَّامِخِ وَالْعَزَّ الْبَادِخِ الشَّرَفِ فَأَهْلُ الْفُرسِ وَهِيَ الثَّانِيَةُ الْأُمَّةُ وَأَمَّا نَاوَاهُمْ مَنْ عَنْهُمْ تُحَامِي وَرُؤُوسَ تَجْمِعُهُمْ مُلُوكُ لَهُمْ وَكَانَتْ الْمُلْكُ لَهَا دَامَ غَيْرَهُمْ أُمَّةٌ نَعْلَمُ وَلَا مُلُوكًا وَأَنُوسَهَا وَدَوَامِ اتِّصَالٍ عَلَى حَظِّهِمْ فِيهِ مَا عَلَى الْأُمُورِ مِنْ وَتَحْتَمِلُهُمْ مَظْلُومُهُمْ عَنْ ظَالِمُهُمْ وَتَدْفَعُ غَارَهُمْ مَنْ بِهِمْ وَتَغْلِبُ سَالِفِهِمْ. عَنْ وَغَائِبُهُمْ أُولَهُمْ عَنْ آخِرُهُمْ ذَلِكَ يَأْخُذُ التَّنْظِيمَ وَأَحْسَنِ

وَالْعَجَمِ الْعَرَبِ فِي

مَنْوُشَهْرَ مُلْكٍ إِلَى نُوحِ ابْنِ سَامِ بْنِ الْآدِ بْنِ أَمِيمِ بْنِ كَيْنُمُورَثَ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً مِنْ أَنْ ذَلِكَ فِي قِيلَ مَا وَأَصَحُّ الثَّانِيَةُ الطَّبَقَةُ مُلُوكِ أَوَّلِ مَنْوُشَهْرَ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً إِلَى السَّلَامِ عَلَيْهِ الْبَشَرِ أَبُو آدَمَ عَنْدَهُمْ هُوَ الَّذِي كَانَهُمْ الْفُرسِ الطَّبَقَةُ مُلُوكِ أَوَّلِ دُوعَ بْنِ كَيْثُبَادَ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً إِلَى مَنْوُشَهْرَ مُلْكٍ وَمِنْ كَامِلَةٍ. سَنَةِ أَلْفِ نَحْوِ الْفُرسِ مُلُوكِ مِنَ الرَّابِعَةِ الطَّبَقَةِ وَهِيَ الطَّوَائِفِ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً إِلَى كَيْثُبَادَ مُلْكٍ وَمِنْ عَامٍ. مَائَتِي مِنْ قَرِيبِ الْفُرسِ مُلُوكِ مِنَ الثَّالِثَةِ أَلْفِ نَحْوِ الْفُرسِ مُلُوكِ مِنَ الثَّالِثَةِ الطَّبَقَةِ مُلُوكِ آخِرِ دَارًا بْنِ لِدَارَا الْإِسْكَانْدَرِ مَقْتَلٍ عِنْدَ ذَلِكَ الْفُرسِ مُلُوكِ مِنَ الطَّبَقَةِ وَهِيَ إِسْفَانِيَارَ بَنِي مُلُوكِ أَوَّلِ السَّاسَانِيَّ بَابَكِ بْنِ أَرْدَشِيرِ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً إِلَى الطَّوَائِفِ مُلْكٍ أَوَّلِ وَمِنْ سَنَةِ. انْقِصَاءً إِلَى بَابَكِ بْنِ أَرْدَشِيرِ مُلْكٍ ابْتِدَاءً وَمِنْ سَنَةِ. وَسِتُّونَ وَإِحْدَى سَنَةِ خَمْسِمَائَةِ الْفُرسِ مُلُوكِ مِنَ الْخَامِسَةِ قَتْلَ عِنْدَ ذَلِكَ الْأَرْضِ مِنَ الْفُرسِ دَوْلَةَ

[Translation: Science among the Persians]

As for the second nation, the Persians: they are a people of towering nobility and exalted glory, the most settled of nations and the noblest in region, and the most prosperous in kings. We know of no nation besides them whose sovereignty endured so long, who had kings that united them and leaders that defended them from those who opposed them, overcame with them those who envied them, and protected their oppressed from their oppressors, and who endured affairs in a way that secured their portion with continuity and permanence and the finest organization, so that the last of them took this over from the first, and the absent from the absent.

[On the Arabs and the Non-Arabs]

The most correct opinion on this is that from the beginning of the reign of Kayumars ibn Amim ibn Aladh ibn Sam ibn Nuh (Noah) to the reign of Manushihr the Persian—who is, according to them, Adam the father of mankind, peace be upon him—to the beginning of the reign of Manushihr, the first king of the second class of Persian kings, was about a thousand complete years. From the reign of Manushihr to the beginning of the reign of Kaythubadh ibn Dua, the first king of the third class of Persian kings, was about two hundred years. From the reign of Kaythubadh to the beginning of the reign of the Tribes (al-Tawa'if), the fourth class of Persian kings, at the killing of Alexander (al-Iskandar) of Dara ibn Dara, the last king of the third class of Persian kings, was about a thousand years. From the beginning of the reign of Azdashir ibn Babak the Sasanian, the first king of the Banu Isfaniyar (the fifth class of Persian kings), was five hundred and sixty-one years. From the beginning of the reign of Azdashir ibn Babak to the end of the Persian state on earth, at the killing [of Yazdagird]...

Chapter Four: Science in Greece

اليونان في العلم

مَمْتَدَّةٌ مُلْكُهُمْ دَارَةٌ وَكَانَتْ بِهَا. الْمُحِيطَةُ وَالْأَمَمُ وَقِسْطَنْطِينِيَّةَ وَالرُّومَ فَلَسْطِينَ أَهْلُ فَهُمْ الْيُونَانِيُّونَ وَأَمَّا مَدِينَتُهُمْ وَكَانَتْ الشَّامَ. بَحْرٌ إِلَى الْقُطْبِ أَقْصَى وَمِنْ الْمَغَارِبِ، فِي شَطْهِ إِلَى الْمَشَارِقِ فِي الْمُتَوَسِّطِ بَحْرٍ شَطٌّ مِنْ مُتَنَوِّعَةٍ. كَثِيرَةٌ وَعُلُومُهُمْ جِدًّا قَدِيمَةٌ دَوْلَتُهُمْ وَكَانَتْ الْإِسْكَنْدَرِيَّةَ. مَدِينَةُ الْعُظْمَى وَهَبَاطِيَا وَجَالِينُوسُ وَبَطْلِيمُوسُ وَأَرِسْطُو وَأَفْلَاطُونُ فَالَيْسُ عِنْدَهُمْ وَالْحِكْمُ الْعُلُومُ فِي تَكَلَّمَ مَنْ أَوَّلَ وَكَانَ الَّذِينَ وَهُمْ وَالْحِكْمُ. الْعُلُومُ أَهْلٌ مِنْ هَؤُلَاءِ إِلَى يُنْسَبُ مَنْ وَجَمِيعُ وَأَرِشْمِيدُسُ وَنُقُومَاخُسُ وَأَقْلِيدُسُ وَبَرْقَلِيْسُ بَلَّغَتْهُمْ. ذَلِكَ فِي مُؤَلَّفَاتِهِمْ وَكَانَتْ قَوَاعِدُهَا وَتَقْيِيدُ أَفْسَامِهَا وَتَرْتِيبُ وَتَوْضِيحُهَا الْعُلُومُ أُصُولٌ بِإِصْلَاحٍ قَامُوا الشَّرْقِ. فِي النَّصَارَى مِنَ الدِّينِ أَهْلٌ وَاتَّخَذَهَا الْمَنَازِرَةَ نَشَرَهَا أَنْ بَعْدَ الْعَرَبِ لُغَةً إِلَى نُقِلَتْ إِنَّمَا ثُمَّ

[Translation: Science in Greece]

As for the Greeks, they are the people of Palestine, Rome, Constantinople, and the surrounding nations. Their kingdom extended from the shore of the Mediterranean Sea in the East to its shore in the West, and from the far north to the Syrian Sea. Their greatest city was the city of Alexandria. Their state was very ancient and their sciences were many and varied.

The first to discourse on the sciences and wisdom among them were Thales, Plato, Aristotle, Ptolemy, Galen, Hippocrates, Proclus, Euclid, Nicomachus, Archimedes, and all those attributed to these in the sciences and wisdom. They were the ones who established the principles of the sciences, elucidated them, arranged their parts, and codified their rules, and their compositions on this were in their own language. Then they were translated into Arabic after the Manadhirah disseminated them and the religious scholars among the Christians in the East adopted them.

Chapter Five: Science in Egypt

مِصْرَ فِي الْعِلْمِ

فِي مِنْهُمْ الْيُونَانِيُّونَ أَخَذَتْهَا مِنْذُ تَبْلُغَ لَمْ وَلَكِنَّهَا نَافِعَةٌ قَدِيمَةٌ عُلُومُهُمْ وَكَانَتْ الْعِلْمُ مِصْرَ أَهْلُ فَهُمْ الْقِبْطُ وَأَمَّا الْأُمَمِ جَمِيعٍ مِنَ الْعُلَمَاءِ إِلَيْهَا وَحَشَدَ لِلْعُلُومِ مَوْطِنًا وَجَعَلَهَا الإسْكَندَرِيَّةَ مَدِينَةً بَنَى الَّذِي الْمَلِكِ بَطْلِيمُوسَ عَهْدِ ذَلِكَ وَمِنْ فِيهَا. وَصَنَفُوا وَنَقَّحُوا إِلَيْهَا أَضَافَ مَا الْيُونَانِ حِكْمٍ مِنْ فِيهَا فَأَدْخَلُوا عُلُومَهُمُ الْقِبْطِ عَنْ فَأَخَذُوا الْعُلُومِ. مِنْ ذَلِكَ وَغَيْرِ وَالْأَدْوِيَّةِ الْعِلَالِ وَعِلْمُ الْكَوَاكِبِ تَأْلِيفٍ وَعِلْمُ الْهَيْئَةِ عِلْمُ

[Translation: Science in Egypt]

As for the Copts, they are the people of Upper Egypt. Their sciences were ancient and beneficial, but they did not advance further since the Greeks took them from them in the time of Ptolemy the king who built the city of Alexandria and made it a center for the sciences, gathering scholars from all nations. They took from the Copts their sciences and incorporated into them Greek wisdom, adding to them, refining them, and composing works on them. Among these were the science of astronomy, the science of the configuration of the planets, the science of causes and remedies, and other sciences.

Chapter Six: Science among the Jews

اليهود في العلم

مِنْ خَرَجُوا لَمَّا إِنَّهُمْ ثُمَّ وَمُلُوكِهِمْ. أَنْبِيَائِهِمْ زَمَنٍ فِي الْأُولَى أَرْمَنَتْهُمْ فِي عُلُومٍ لَهُمْ كَانَتْ فَقَدْ الْيَهُودُ وَأَمَّا عَلَى مُوَاطَّيَّةٍ وَلَا بَقَاءٍ أَهْلَ يَكُونُوا لَمْ لِأَنَّهُمْ وَتَنَكَّرَتْ عُلُومُهُمْ ضَاعَتْ وَالْعَرَبُ الْعَجَمُ بِلَادٍ فِي وَتَفَرَّقُوا بِلَادِهِمْ عُلَمَائِهِمْ أَشْهَرٍ مِنْ وَكَانَ وَالتَّوْحِيدِ. وَالشَّرَائِعِ التَّعْبُدِ فِي عُلُومًا الْأَنْبِيَاءِ تَوَارِثَ مِنْ حَفِظُوا قَدْ وَلَكِنَّهُمْ الْعِلْمَ. وَغَيْرَهَا. وَالطَّبِّ وَالْفَلَسَفَةِ الْكَلَامِ عِلْمٍ فِي صَنَفٍ الَّذِي الْأَنْدَلُسِيُّ مَيْمُونُ بْنُ مُوسَى

[Translation: Science among the Jews]

As for the Jews, they had sciences in their earliest times, in the era of their prophets and kings. But when they left their lands and dispersed into the lands of the non-Arabs and the Arabs, their sciences were lost and forgotten because they were not a people of endurance or perseverance in science. However, they did preserve from the inheritance of the prophets sciences concerning worship, religious laws, and monotheism. Among their most famous scholars was Musa ibn Maymun (Maimonides) al-Andalusi, who composed works on the science of theology, philosophy, medicine, and other subjects.

Chapter Seven: Science among the Arabs

العرب في العلم

لِصَغَرِ عَلَيْهِ تَوَاضُّعٌ وَلَا بِالْعِلْمِ تَغْنَى لَا مِنْهُمْ الْبَادِيَّةُ وَكَانَتْ حَاضِرَةً. وَأُمَّةٌ بَادِيَّةٌ أُمَّةٌ أَمْتَانِ: فَهَمَّ الْعَرَبُ وَأَمَّا وَالسَّحَرُ وَالنُّجُومُ الطَّبُّ فِي الْجَاهِلِيَّةِ فِي عُلُومٍ لَهُمْ كَانَتْ فَقَدْ الْحَاضِرَةُ وَأَمَّا الْبِلَادُ. فِي وَتَنَقَّلُوا مَعِيشَتَهُمْ وَالْفَلَاحَ لِلنَّجَاةِ سَبَبًا وَجَعَلَهُ عَلَيْهِ وَحَثَّ الْعِلْمَ طَلَبٍ فِي وَشَرَعَ الْإِسْلَامُ جَاءَ لَمَّا ثُمَّ ذَلِكَ. وَغَيْرِ وَالنَّحْوِ وَالشَّعْرِ أَهْلٌ قَلِيلٌ زَمَنٍ فِي أَصْبَحُوا حَتَّى الْعَرَبُ بِلُغَةٍ وَتَضْيِيرَهَا الْأُخْرَى الْأُمَمِ مِنْ وَنَقَلُوا الْعُلُومَ طَلَبٍ فِي الْعَرَبُ اجْتَهَدَ وَفُتُونُ. عُلُومُ

فَتَقَلُّوْهَا الْأَوَائِلَ لِعُلُومٍ تَعَرَّضُوا إِنَّهُمْ ثُمَّ وَالتَّفْسِيرِ وَالحَدِيثِ وَالفقه الكَلَامِ عِلْمٌ إِلَيْهِ نَشَطُوا مَا أَوَّلَ وَكَانَ مَعْشَرٌ وَأَبُو وَالتَّبَاتَانِي الْفَرَعَانِي النُّجُومِ عِلْمٌ فِي الْعَرَبِ أَشْهَرُ مِنْ وَكَانَ كَثِيرَةً. أَشْيَاءٌ إِلَيْهَا وَأَصَافُوا فِيهَا وَصَنَّفُوا وَالتَّبَرُوجِيُّ الْمَجَرُطِيُّ بَطْلِيمُوسُ الْهَيْئَةِ وَفِي رِشْدٍ. وَابْنُ وَالْمَجُوسِيُّ سَيْنَا وَابْنُ الرَّازِيِّ الطَّبِّ وَفِي الْفَلَكِيِّ. سَيْنَا وَابْنُ وَالفَارَابِيُّ الْكِنْدِيُّ الْفَلَسَفَةِ وَفِي وَالْكَشِّيُّ. الْخَوَارِزْمِيُّ الْحَسَبِ الْعِلْمِ وَفِي الطُّوسِيِّ. الدِّينِ وَشَرَفَ رِشْدٍ. وَابْنُ

[Translation: Science among the Arabs]

As for the Arabs, they are two nations: a desert nation and a settled nation. The desert among them did not concern itself with science nor persevere in it due to the hardship of their livelihood and their movement from land to land. As for the settled people, they had sciences in the Jahili period in medicine, astrology, magic, poetry, grammar, and other subjects. Then when Islam came and legislated the pursuit of knowledge, encouraged it, and made it a means of salvation and success, the Arabs strove in seeking the sciences, translating them from other nations, and rendering them into Arabic, until in a short time they became a people of sciences and arts.

The first [sciences] they were active in were theology (*kalam*), jurisprudence (*fiqh*), *hadith*, and [Qur'anic] exegesis (*tafsir*). Then they turned to the sciences of the ancients, translating them, composing works on them, and adding much to them. Among the most famous Arabs in the science of astrology were al-Farghani, al-Battani, and Abu Ma'shar the astronomer. In medicine: al-Razi, Ibn Sina (Avicenna), al-Majusi, and Ibn Rushd (Averroes). In astronomy: Ptolemy al-Majriti, al-Bitruji (Alpetragius), and Sharaf al-Din al-Tusi. In arithmetic: al-Khwarizmi and al-Kashshi. In philosophy: al-Kindi, al-Farabi, Ibn Sina, and Ibn Rushd.

Editorial and Scholarly Notes

On the Manuscript and Its Preservation

The 1912 edition by Pere Louis Cheikho, S.J. (1859–1927) represents the first modern critical edition of this important work. Cheikho based his edition on a single manuscript preserved in the Oriental collections of Europe. The manuscript, as Cheikho describes it, is written in a clear hand resembling Persian script on thick yellowed paper, bound skillfully in gold-colored paper.

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* has survived in a relatively small number of manuscripts compared to other major works of the Islamic scientific tradition. This may be attributed to the fact that it was composed in al-Andalus and did not circulate as widely in the eastern Islamic lands as works produced in Baghdad or other eastern centers.

On the Author

Sa'id al-Andalusi (1029–1070 CE), whose full name is Abu al-Qasim Sa'id ibn Ahmad ibn Sa'id al-Taghlabi, was a jurist and scholar of Toledo. Born in Almeria (al-Mariyya) in 420 AH, he served as a judge (*qadi*) in Toledo under the Hammudid amir Yahya ibn Dhi al-Nun. He died in Shawwal 462 AH (July 1070 CE).

On the Structure of the Work

The *Kitab Tabaqat al-Umam* is divided into two main parts:

1. **The Ancient Nations** (*al-Umam al-Qadima*): Seven nations that existed in earliest times—the Persians, the Chaldeans, the Greeks, the Egyptians, the Jews, the Arabs, and the Indians.
2. **The Islamic Nations** (*al-Umam al-Islamiyya*): A classification of the nations that embraced Islam, with special attention to their contributions to the sciences.

The work is notable for being one of the earliest attempts at a systematic history of science organized by civilizations, predating similar European efforts by several centuries.

On the Scientific Content

Al-Andalusi's work contains valuable information about:

- The state of astronomy and astrology in various ancient civilizations
- The transmission of scientific knowledge between cultures
- The role of translation in preserving Greek scientific heritage
- Early Indian contributions to mathematics and astronomy (including the decimal system)
- The development of scientific institutions such as the House of Wisdom in Baghdad

Selected Bibliography

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